

(iv) **Bad Lines** : Sometimes because of bad lines we may not hear the voice of the person on other side clearly; the same may happen to our voice too. In such situations we should stop talking and explain clearly that we would call back when the lines get bettered.

(v) **Wrong Numbers** : Sometimes after dialling we find that we are through to some wrong number. We should ask the other person the phone number with due request. However, we should not expect them to tell us their number. We should feel sorry to them for being a cause to such an inconvenience.

#### 21.8.7 Difficult Callers

Sometimes there may be calls from rude and aggressive callers who are complaining about something. We should not retaliate in response. Maintaining a professional attitude we should deal with them politely noting down their problem and accept responsibility as a representative of the organisation and feel sorry for the inconvenience with a promise to look into the matter constructively at the earliest convenience. We should follow-up immediately in this regard. Also we should not take any insult personally. Sometimes by putting up right combination of 'yes' or 'no' and 'complete answer' questions we may determine the type of response. However, only open-ended questions may worsen the situation. We may also ask such callers what they should suggest us to do to help them solve their problems. This may turn them polite and cool in further conversation.

#### REVIEW QUESTIONS

1. Explain the nature and purpose of listening. What is the significance of effective listening ?
2. Differentiate between :



'Indian Oils', or

Chairman's Office' or

'Accounts Deptt.' Mahesh speaking'

(iii) Do not shout. Infer that you have to raise your voice if you hear from the other end, 'pardon' or some such word.

(iv) Avoid, 'Yeah', 'Yep', 'Hi-ya', etc. These words are chummy and out of character with good business talk.

Instead of saying 'he hasn't come to office yet'.

Say, 'He is not in the office just now but I will be glad to take a massage'.

Instead of saying, 'He flew to Hyderabad yesterday but won't be back until tomorrow'.

Say, "He is out of town but will be in the office tomorrow, May I help you".

(v) Use your natural voice. Wait till you hear fully from the other end.

(vi) Be loud and clear in long distance calls. Use precise words, never chew anything while generally over the phone, and especially in calls from long distance. Jot down points.

(vii) In all types of calls, never waste much time on personal talks.

### 21.8.5 Problems of Telephonic Conversation.

In telephonic conversation many problems arise due to unexpected mechanical problems, and difficult callers. All these problems should be attended to properly as discussed below :

#### 21.8.6 Mechanical Problems

(i) **Telephone System** : We should know how our telephone system works, which buttons are to be used to transfer calls, what we should do to redial a number. We should know how the memory of our system works. There are various functions that our system could do. Unless we are aware of these we could not perform or use the system effectively. Hence we should know the scope and limitations of our system.

(ii) **Cross-Connection** : Sometimes when we are talking on phone there is an interference caused by other callers. Such interruptions hamper smooth conversation. When such an interference stops we should establish the link again and politely suggest them to redial.

(iii) **Getting Disconnected** : When we get disconnected in the middle of the conversation, the person who initiated the call should redial. However, if the client were important to us and if we happened to have his or her telephone number, we may call back.



of its activities, the knowledge of our section or the department, our products and services and the information regarding our customers. We should have a special pad and pen ready to jot down the important points emerging out of our conversation. As a preparation an up-to-date telephone directory, and a complete list of queries should also be kept ready.

(ii) **Controlling the Call** : The control over the call starts with lifting the receiver. We should promptly lift the receiver when we receive a call. We should lift it hearing three to four rings. A frustrating voice is not liked by any one. We start making a call by greeting the receiver giving our own identity, may not be the name but indeed by giving the designation and the department we belong to. A friendly and cheerful tone shows our interest. Our friendly tone shows our interest. It makes the caller respond immediately by revealing his or her identity. Using the caller's name in our conversation makes us sound friendly and helpful.

For a sound control we should have our questions for the caller ready to extract all relevant information from the caller. We should try to avoid the caller waiting, holding or hanging on to the receiver. This hints at our positive treatment. Nor should we hold two conversations simultaneously. Even if there occurs any interruption we should ignore that and continue paying attention to the caller or the receiver.

During a telephonic conversation we should be very particular about jotting down or informing names, phone numbers, addresses or any other important details. We should also know how to conclude the conversation with an appropriate summary at the end. For transferring calls we should know our telephones system, the buttons to press for transferring calls. When transferring the call we should keep the caller informed. Similarly to whom we are transferring the call we should inform him or her about the identity and purpose of the caller.

(iii) **Follow-up** : The final stage of telephonic communication deals with the essential follow-up with regard to the promises made. If we say that we would call the person back soon with the necessary information we should do it. If any message has been jotted down from the caller, it should reach the person concerned. If the person concerned has to reply to the caller we should also find out whether that person has called back or not. We should reassure the waiting caller for some information that it will be passed on to him or her soon.

#### 21.8.4 Skills for Telephonic Conversation

(i) Do not allow the telephone to ring, for, it is not only annoying, but also reflects your promptness. Keep a pencil and pad always ready to take notes of conversation. Place the telephone within easy reach and preferably to your left unless you are a left-hander.

(ii) Put your company first. In a company with private branch exchange, the moment you receive a call in your department adopt any of the following or like styles :



may get untowardly affected if we do not happen to get an interesting voice on phone. Many of us do not know how to encode messages extemporaneously and because this or may be because of our inexperience we may turn panicky and lose alertness and concentration.

One of the means to deal with these deficiencies in listening is to concentrate on the subject matter by jotting down important contents of the message on a telephone pad. This practice helps in keeping a record on the important facts, saves time from these being repeated and in dealing with unavoidable distractions.

As on telephone the caller is to be constantly intimated about the fact of our listening to his or her voice, therefore, at the end of or sometimes in the middle of conversation we have to use verbal nods like 'Yes', 'Yeah', 'I See', 'right', 'oh yes' 'that's right' 'okay' 'that's true' etc., so that the caller does not lose his or her continuity in communication.

### 21.8.2 Speaking through Telephone

Lacking a visual contact even if we make use of non-verbal means as we often do unconsciously, these means remain unnoticed and uncoded. As these body signs do not reach the listener we have to depend on our voice only for communicating our message. How we transmit our message with the verbal tools like modulations of our voice, yielding, variations in tone, stressing, repeating, making different kinds of conventionally acceptable sounds, laughing, weeping and shouting, we make up for the loss of visual contact. As for listening there is a need of verbal nods; for speaking on telephone there must be an appropriate substitution for all non-verbal means used in communication.

For a successful use of our voice in telephonic conversation, we should be neither too familiar nor too alien to the caller. We should know how to create a picture of our message in the mind of the listener. Our voice should be jargon free, matching the pitch of the caller. A positive or helpful language always makes us effective. Our tone expresses our emotional state. To avoid the play of emotion in the tone of our voice, we should smile. Smiling relaxes the vocal cords and it instantly makes our voice friendly and relaxed. If we do not sound bored, tired, aggressive, unsure, harassed or annoyed, we can succeed in helping the caller to express himself or herself effectively resulting in a successful conversation on telephone.

### 21.8.3 Developing Telephonic Skills

A telephonic conversation continues through three stages. For an effective telephonic communication these stages need due attention and specific skills as discussed below :

(i) **Preparation for the Call :** In business communication on telephone for receiving and making calls our role as the receiver or as the caller requires an appropriate knowledge of the organization we represent, an up-to-date knowledge



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price we have to pay to get people to let us talk. Remember the old saying, "the good lord gave us two ears and only one tongue with a purpose".

**9. Restate what the Speaker has Said :** Restate what the speaker has said in your own words. This is called Paraphrasing. There are two reasons for rephrasing. It is an excellent control device to check whether you have listened carefully. You can't paraphrase accurately if your mind has been wandering. It is also a control for accuracy. By rephrasing what the speaker has said in your own words and feeding it back to the speaker, you verify the accuracy of your understanding.

Restate the person's feeling, briefly but accurately, to serve as a mirror. This encourages the speaker to continue to talk.

When the other person touches on a point and you do not want to know more about it, simply repeat his statement as a question.

## 21.8 SKILLS IN TELEPHONIC CONVERSATION

In face-to-face communication we have a great advantage to express ourselves verbally as well as non-verbally. We can make use of our body language to strengthen the message content. Our body language not only fills in the gaps remaining in the verbal means but also brings clarity to the message. Hence, in face-to-face communication the listener gets both verbal and non-verbal signifies to decode to get the intent of the message. The speaker or the sender of the message can watch the nature of response from the change in facial expression and other gestures, if any verbal clues are not given by the receiver or the listener and can know the impact of the transmission of his or her speech. Accordingly, gathering the impression from the receiver, the sender can act upon that and modify the manner and matter of speaking. He or she not only gets his or her message across but also satisfies the receiver.

On telephone though two people exchange messages there is no visual contact. Also on telephone there is a limitation of time. In communication neither the receiver nor the sender gets any quick clues to decode or encode the message. He or she has to believe in his or her ears or in his or her voice. Therefore, two crucial aspects of telephonic conversation are : (i) listening, and (ii) speaking (only with verbal means).

### 21.8.1 Listening Through Telephone

On telephone one cannot dare lose concentration while listening. Unlike in face-to-face communication, listening in telephonic communication requires a greater effort. If we lose alertness or go absent-minded the speaker will not understand it and will not stop talking. In the process we may miss an important portion of his or her message. Neither could we anticipate what the caller is going to say nor could we guess the mood of the speaker from the call immediately.

While a telephonic conversation is going on we may get distracted by other activities happening or the presence of any other person around us. Our listening



because a close-eyed listener may have claimed a better concentration but have lacked the opportunity to observe many non-verbal clues used by the speaker with a view to add meaning to his or her message.

An effective speaker takes note of the gestural and postural signals given by the listener regarding his or her speech as clues to adjust the pace and pattern of his or her speech to the needs shown by these listeners and the interaction can then become a powerful booster for the participation of both the parties in the communication.

**3. Upright Posture :** Posture too is very important for an effective listening. An upright posture helps a listener to have better concentration. At the same time it is seen by the speaker to be a positive, physically relaxed effecting mental relaxations too, which in effect, indeed, hinder effective concentration and a successful listening.

If we sit leaning slightly forward, it is a sign of showing interest and it simultaneously encourages the speaker to let his or her thoughts and expressions flow. On the contrary if we lean back or away from the speaker, it often expresses a lack of interest on the part of the listener or a disinterested gesture.

**4. Remove Distractions :** Avoid actions that suggest your mind is somewhere else. Distractions make the speaker feel you are bored or uninterested. More importantly, they indicate that you are not fully attentive and may be missing part of the message that the speaker wants to convey. The sources of distractions come from : (i) within you, as when you daydream, (ii) the outside environment (outside noise, people passing by, etc), and (iii) the speaker (speaker's accent, mannerism, language, delivery, etc).

**5. Be Patient :** Avoid interrupting the speaker. Let the speaker complete speaking before you respond. Allow time for the speaker to complete.

Remain objective and do not get upset by what he is saying. Listen patiently to what the speaker has to say, even though you may believe it is wrong or irrelevant.

**6. Avoid Arguments and Criticism :** Avoid arguments about facts; refrain from saying, "That just is not so", or "Prove it". You may want to review evidence later, but a review is irrelevant to how the person feels now.

Any argument or criticism puts the other person on the defensive. Do not argue. Even if you win the argument, you lose.

**7. Ask Questions :** Analyse what you hear and ask questions. This assures and encourages the speaker because it shows that you are listening. It helps to develop points further, besides providing clarification and ensuring understanding.

**8. Don't Overtalk :** You cannot listen well if you are talking. When you have to talk, never talk too much. Most of us would rather speak our own ideas than listen to what someone else says. Too many of us listen only because it is the



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### 21.6.7 Evaluation

Critical and analytical listening is necessary for evaluation. Evaluation demands more than comprehension. The listener must analyse the speaker's reasoning and judge the value of logic and proofs. To evaluate we have to listen to the speaker's analysis of problems and the type of reasoning he uses besides recognising the motive appeals he employs and their relation to his reasoning. In addition, we have to pay close attention to the wording used by the speaker and the amount and reliability of his supporting material.

### 21.7 TIPS FOR EFFECTIVE LISTENING

1. Establish Rapport with the Speaker: An important requisite for effective listening is to develop a positive chemistry between a listener and a speaker. It helps the listener to keep track of what speaker speaks and also helps him or her to prevent his or her mind from going wayward. As the speaker has his or her own responsibility to create this chemistry, the listener too has an equal responsibility if the interaction between the two is to become effective. The normal battery of interpreting non-verbal clues in communication is very relevant.

2. Make Eye Contact: For interpreting the non-verbal clues a proper eye contact is particularly important. Some people may claim that when they listen keeping their eyes closed, they listen most effectively. They may claim that this may act as aid to better their communication. However, even if one takes the claim at the face value a listener with his or her eyes closed is not seen to be concentrating as he or she does not offer the same evidence of synergistic listening as does the more attentive listener.

A better practice is thus required to look at the speaker seeking for a positive eye contact with him or her and to go beyond that to gestures which not only support him or her but also express him or her more clearly. If we do not look at the other person with whom we talk or whom we listen to is a way of manifesting unconcern and showing a lack of interest.

Facial gestures are particularly helpful in listening and interpreting the message. The raised eye brows, the critical smile, the affirmative nod, the negative shake, the puzzled frown, all these help in making the communication effective. The speaker expresses a lot through non-verbal means and the listener too suggests a lot about the progress or success of his or her listening in communication through these means.

In this context this also needs mentioning that although an eye contact helps one in reading the facial gestures, there may be exceptions when a listener with open eyes too goes absent-minded or begins thinking something else or getting distracted by the speaker's appearance and mannerisms and lose the very purpose of positive listening. Indeed, the person making an eye contact presents more an evidence to the speaker of his or her effective listening to judge and get informed than that which is displayed by a listener with closed eyes. This is so



## Listening Skills

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## Listening Skills

above the noise. Likewise focusing our thought on the speaker's expressed ideas helps us to grasp them clearly.

Concentration is partly a matter of attitude. The listener has to positively wish to concentrate on receiving that message which a speaker is trying to send. If the speaker is difficult to follow, there is particular need for the listener's determination to concentrate on what is being said.

Concentration is helped by alertness. Mental alertness is helped by physical alertness. Good health is important for a listener to be effective.

Our comprehension of someone else's speech will be increased further if we learn to recognise the arrangement of the speaker's ideas. What is the central idea ? What are the main points, and how are they arranged ? What are the minor points, and to which main point do they relate ? We have to learn to listen for the idea structure, noting the relationship of illustrative detail to the main points.

Relating what we hear to what we already know helps us to improve comprehension. However we have to avoid letting our opinions prevent our listening to new ideas. Usually a receptive, open-minded attitude is most conducive to understanding.

### 5. Appreciation

Appreciation requires a relaxed, receptive and imaginative attitude on the listener's part. Appreciative listening requires :

- (a) Physical and mental relaxation
- (b) Receptive attitude,
- (c) Imaginative projection and empathy.

Picturing what the speaker describes, allows our enthusiasm and emotion to reflect that of the speaker.

### 6. Note-taking

Note-taking has been recommended as an important aid to the listener. It also helps the speaker by giving or generating confidence when he or she sees that his or her listeners are sufficiently interested to take notes; the pattern of eye-contact when the note-taker looks up can be very positive and encouraging and the speaker's timing and matter are aided — he or she can see when a note-taker is writing hard and can then make an effective use of pauses and stresses. Such pauses and stresses generated by the needs of the listener, can contribute powerfully to the speaker's authority.

A note-taker further paraphrases the speaker's thought but in fewer words. It neither adds anything new nor changes its intent, nor even poses question but it summarizes the speaker's thought or feelings and informs how they have been understood.

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speaker is saying and follow private side-tracks. A listener also may have to counter constantly within, the counter arguments to whatever a speaker may have been saying. This applies equally to the thought processes of people who are either listening to a programmed speech or are engaged in a dialogue.

The important guidelines to develop listening skills are discussed below :

### 1. Concentration

The first skill to effective listening is the art of concentration. Concentration is, to a great extent, a matter of attitude. A listener while listening should inculcate the habit of concentrating on the message which a speaker is trying to send.

The right kind of concentration depends upon his or her determination. It is true that it is difficult to follow some speakers either because of their voice problems occurring due to improper pronunciation caused by mother tongue influences, regional effects, the volume and pace of articulation or because of the form they choose to encode their message. There is then a specific determination required at the end of listener to concentrate on what is being said.

### 2. Mental Alertness

One's concentration can be improved by one's mental alertness. Mental alertness is increased by physical alertness — not simply by one's physical fitness, but also the way one positions one's body, the limbs and the head.

Every person develops a different and peculiar posture to have an appropriate concentration of his or her own kind. One should be self interrogative and self-assessing with regard to his or her qualities of competence as a listener. Is my competence as a listener normally poor? Is my time span of total concentration for a very short while? Is my alertness effective? Does my technique for overloading this require an intensive note-taking? Am I wrong in revealing the structure of the speaker's message?

It may be that a speaker is using a technique for preparation and presentation radically different from that of a listener's technique.

### 2. Empathy

Empathy is the ability to put ourselves in the speaker's shoes; in his frame of mind. When we empathise, we try to understand what the speaker wants to communicate rather than what we want to understand. Knowledge of the speaker and flexibility on our part are essential for empathy. For effective listening, the listener should try to perceive the speaker's frame of reference.

### 4. Comprehension

Good listening is more than merely hearing the speaker. It includes grasping and understanding. To achieve this, the listener must concentrate on the speaker's ideas and words. Concentration on the speaker's words helps us to hear them



**EXHIBIT 21.1****IMPROVING LISTENING ABILITY**

1. Desire to Listen : The first step one needs in effective listening is to create a desire to learn and to listen. One should analyze one's own shortcomings consistently as a listener and try to overcome them. One should learn to have a propensity to listen more than to talk.

2. Resisting Distractions : In the process of listening there may be many distractions at physical or mental level. Because we have a pace of thinking faster than that of speaking, our attention begins to wander while we listen to someone. When this happens, we should make a conscious effort to bring our mind back to what is being said. We should be alert to the speaker's message that is transmitted through verbal as well as non-verbal means. We should not be diverted by his or her physical appearance, the delivery or mannerism of the speaker. We should concentrate on the message that the speaker tries to convey.

3. Focus on the Message : Skilled listeners focus on listening more to the message than to the matter of listening. Each speech contains a limited number of points. Our adapting to a right manner of listening makes us identify these points which, together, convey the main message of a speech. At the same time, we should also listen to the statements that support the inclination or the intent of the speaker. We should evaluate the evidence of this support in terms of its accuracy, objectivity, relevance and adequacy in the message.

4. Delay Evaluation and Premature Conclusions : We should give the speaker adequate time to say by all means. We should not jump to conclusions. First we should try to understand the message, then evaluate it. Premature judgement hampers effective listening. We should try to remove mental or emotional blocks, if any, which prevent us from listening to something or someone. We should remember that a good listener always keeps his mind open to ideas and information and eyes keen to observe how they are uttered.

5. Taking Notes : We should know that our perceiving the essence of the speech is not the end of listening. We should also know how to record what we listen. Learning how to take notes to keep track with the speaker's message should be the main thrust of the listener. Also how a listener drives the main thrust of the speaker's message home is also very important. The technique of note-taking is to acquire the main points by writing the key words used by the speaker to communicate his or her message. Taking down notes guides us to become a more attentive and a creative listener.

**21.6 DEVELOPING LISTENING SKILLS**

One requires energy to concentrate on listening to what is being said, to concentrate on interpreting and understanding what has been listened to and to evaluate objectively that has been understood. Incompetent listeners do not deploy the right amount of energy. The attention of the listeners may drift from what the



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this process it is possible to frame a reply that will actually respond to the speaker's message. Effective listening is invariably empathetic. It requires an ability to listen to their feelings as well as their words.

### 21.5. BARRIERS TO ACTIVE LISTENING

Listening requires hard work as it involves concentration. It takes energy to concentrate on listening to what is being said, to concentrate on understanding what has been heard, and to make an objective evaluation of ways. The inefficient understood. In practice, many listeners fail in a number of ways. The inefficient listeners may:

- (i) Drift, with their attention drifting away from what the speaker is saying.
- (ii) Criticise the speaker or the delivery. Instead of focusing on what the speaker is saying, his or her thoughts and feelings, they may focus on how he or she is saying it. In the process of trying to notice errors in accent, grammar etc., they fail to listen.
- (iii) Counter, constantly trying to find counter-arguments to whatever the speaker is saying.
- (iv) Listen only for facts and not for feelings and emotions, and want to skip the details.
- (v) Get overstimulated when questioning or opposing an idea, and overreacting to certain words and phrases.
- (vi) Filter by excluding from their understanding those parts of the message which do not readily fit with their own frame of reference.
- (vii) Assume in advance that the subject is uninteresting and unimportant.
- (viii) Withdraw attention, start daydreaming.
- (ix) Fake attention, which the speaker can easily see.
- (x) Hear only what they expect to hear, because of preconceived notions about the speaker or the situation.
- (xi) Accept only those communications that are consistent with their existing beliefs.
- (xii) Distort by interpreting the message in ways which are different from the speaker's intentions.
- (xiii) Create distractions, thereby not listening to the speaker fully.
- (xiv) Interrupt unnecessarily, discouraging and irritating the speaker.
- (xv) Allow emotional words to block the message etc.



## Listening Skills

we think he is worth listening to, and want him to know that we are the kind of person he can talk to.

The subtle but most important aspect of this is that it is the demonstration of the message that works. While it is most difficult to convince someone that we respect him or her by saying so, we are much more likely to pass this message across by really behaving that way and by actually having and showing respect for this person. Listening does this most effectively.

## 21.4 LEVELS OF LISTENING

There are three levels of listening, viz. : (i) Marginal, (ii) Evaluative, and (iii) Projective.

These are discussed below :

(i) **Marginal Listening** : If the pace of speaking of the speaker is slow the listener does a marginal listening, which implies that the listener may let his/her mind stray while someone is talking. This in consequence can lead further to a lack of understanding and even an insult shown to the speaker. Many of us have experienced the situation in which, when we are speaking to someone, we realize that the mind of the person listening to us is away from what we are speaking. The person may be hearing the words spoken but the words hardly communicate any sense to him/her.

(ii) **Evaluative Listening** : This occurs when a listener gets some free time to evaluate the speaker's message during the oral communication. When the sender transmits the message to the receiver he/she does not accept the message and the communication ceases. This occurs because the receiver begins to develop a response contrary to the intent of the message. Instead of one idea being transmitted and held by two people, two ideas develop, neither of which is really communicated. If the listener gets too much time to disapprove or approve of what is being said, he/she gets hardly any time to understand it fully. This is particularly true when the speech or message is loaded with emotion, or when it threatens the security, identity or status of the receiver.

(iii) **Projective Listening** : This listening provides the listeners with the greatest potential for effective communication to utilize their time fully. Listeners, with an empathetic gesture attempt to project themselves into the position of the speaker and understand what is implied in the speaker's viewpoint. This kind of listening is called a projective listening. Effective listening must precede any kind of evaluation. Only after understanding what has been said the individuals could equip themselves how to evaluate it or comment on it. A listener could speak for himself or herself only after feeling the speaker accurately. He/she should relate the ideas and feeling to the speaker's satisfaction only after such listening. There is no need for the listener to agree with the statements of the speaker but there is a need for him/her to understand them as the speaker intended. Only through



2. **Pretending Listening** : It means pretending through facial expressions that communicated message is listened. Here, nothing like listening takes place, just hearing is there.

3. **Selective Listening** : It means not taking the message as it is, but adding or deducting according to one's own whims and wishes i.e., selecting the 'desired' part and ignoring the 'undesired' part of the message. This type of listening leads to strengthen one's own beliefs and restrains further learning. It usually happens in selective listening that the listener tries to identify himself with the situation either partially or totally and attempts to find his autobiography in the lives of others.

4. **Empathic Listening** : It involves listening not only through ears but also through eyes and heart. It is listening intently and intensively to understand the person fully, deeply both emotionally as well as intellectually. Some people feel that empathic listening is risky as it means becoming open and vulnerable to other person's influence, while other feel that empathy for the speaker is an essential requirement of effective listening.

5. **Listening for Mutual Creativity** : It is a higher form of listening. The listening to inspire mutual creativity is responsible for many breakthroughs in the world. Listening for mutual creativity is rooted in two questions. What do you most want ? And How can I help you get what you most want ? To listen in total support of other people, To be for their goals and aspirations in your own body, mind and spirit — may well be the greatest gift you can give your fellow human beings.

This listening is synergistic in nature. The terms 'synergy' means that whole is greater than sum of its parts. Listening for creativity not only smooths but accelerates the understanding process through communion of hearts and minds. This listening relieves the persons from stress and strain, soothes their hearts and helps them to bring the idea lying in the crust of their subconscious minds to the conscious surface. Thus it leads to mutual creativity.

6. **Intuitive Listening** : Intuitive listening, like listening for mutual creativity, is a higher form of listening. It means listening through intuitive mind by silencing the other internal dialogues going simultaneously.

### What do we Communicate by Listening ?

Many feel that listening is passive and that it does not communicate anything to the speaker. Actually, nothing could be farther from the truth. By consistently listening to a speaker we convey the idea that we are interested in him as a person, and that we think that what he is feeling is important; that we respect his thoughts, and even if we don't agree with them, we consider them valid; that we are not trying to change him or evaluate him; just want to understand him; that



be informative. In the professional world, listening turns out to be a very significant function. Apart from going through manuals and other written materials, employees of an organisation do gather a lot of information about their jobs by listening to their colleagues and superiors. In addition to the formal kind of communication, the informal and the inter-personal transactions of messages play a significant role in the performing of the day to day work : Harmonious personal relationship that smoothenes these transactions, can be established through effective listening.

Listening indeed plays a substantial and definitive role in the process of decision-making. Very often, company executives work up on their listening skills before deciding on the course of action.

### 21.2.1 Listening and Hearing

Some people confuse hearing with listening. But listening is something more than hearing. Hearing is simply a physiological process in which the frequency of sound waves produced make our eardrums vibrate. These vibrations, then, are carried to the inner ear (cochlea), where these vibrations are translated into electrochemical impulses and further they are carried to the central auditory system of the brain. The brain then recognizes these impulses and identifies them as sounds. This process is very fast and automatic and requires hardly any effort. In fact, we are not able to stop it unless we use ear plugs of some kind to block the aural passage. Listening, on the other hand, first involves paying close attention to the sounds that come in combinations and contrasts and thereby form the speech and then its nature and intent is interpreted and inferred internally by the brain with a decoding system as it is tuned. Technically, it would be correct to say that once the process of interpretation and interference begins, listening occurs. The process, in short, involves analyzing speech sounds, organizing them into recognizable patterns, interpreting the patterns and then understanding the message by inferring the meaning.

### 21.2.2 Listening and Thinking

We can think much faster than we can talk. Our brain works with hundreds of words in addition to those we hear. It means that our brain will continue to think at high speed while the spoken words arrive at low speed. That is, we can listen and still have some spare time for our own thinking. How this spare time is used holds the key to how well a person can listen to the spoken word.

### 21.3 TYPES OF LISTENING

Listening has the following kinds :

1. Attentive Listening : It involves paying attention on the words that are being spoken rather than understanding the head and heart of the person speaking. Attentive listening is said to an effective listening.

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of this skill is primarily responsible for many of the problems we experience with people. Effective human relations is based heavily on good listening skills. Poor listeners are usually also poor negotiators and are also ineffective in crisis situations.

Effective listening is one of the critical skills related to effective communication. It requires more than merely hearing the speaker. It requires grasping and understanding. It includes active, empathetic and supportive behaviours.

### Significance of Good Listening

- ✓ 1. An attentive listener stimulates better speaking by the speaker.
- ✓ 2. A good listener learns more than the indifferent listener.
- ✓ 3. A good listener learns to :
  - ✓ (a) distinguish fact from opinion,
  - ✓ (b) understand and evaluate inferences and reasoning,
  - ✓ (c) detect prejudices, assumptions, attitudes.
- ✓ 4. A good listener can often restructure vague speaking into clearer meaning.

Research has revealed the following facts about listening :

1. Listening skills can be improved by training and instructions.
2. When improvement in listening is achieved, it may not be permanent.
3. There is a distinct difference between speaking rate and listening rate.
4. Generally there is a high correlation between listening and intelligence.
5. One quarter of our waking time is spent on listening.
6. Even if the rate of speaking is increased by as much as 100%, the listening rate does not suffer.

### 21.2 NATURE AND PURPOSE OF LISTENING

Linguistic skills of expression consist of speaking and writing for sending messages, and listening and reading for receiving them. Generally we spend more time on listening than on speaking in oral communication. For being efficient business managers listening is the most significant skill to be inculcated in job related assignments in their firms. Effective listening requires paying attention, interpreting, and remembering sound stimuli.

There are various objectives of Listening : to learn, to increase one's understanding, to increase one's options and to relieve one's boredom. Commonly, we tend to listen to those matters that are of our interests, attitudes and beliefs. However, at times we do not like to listen to unrelated subjects that may although



# 21

## Listening Skills

### CHAPTER OUTLINE

- 21.1 Significance of Listening
- 21.2 Nature and Purpose of Listening
- 21.3 Types of Listening
- 21.4 Levels of Listening
- 21.5 Barriers to Active Listening
- 21.6 Developing Listening Skills
- 21.7 Tips for Effective Listening
- 21.8 Skills in Telephonic Conversation

At times we feel that people have not understood us the way we wanted them to. The main reason for this is failure on the part of the listener to listen effectively. Of course, there are also instances where the speaker might not have conveyed the message effectively. Nonetheless, the importance of effective listening cannot be undermined in the communication process. At the same time, speaking effectively is quite important. So, we can say that both speaking and listening skills are necessary for communication to serve its purpose.

Much of our activities involve communication, especially in the work environment in banks. So, these two aspects of communication—namely listening and speaking are particularly essential to us in our work place, where we have to deal with colleagues, superiors and, more importantly, our customers. For want of these two skills, many times problems crop up. These may affect customer relations, which may prove detrimental to the interests of the organisation. In this chapter, we shall concentrate on the techniques to develop listening skills for effective communication.

### 21.1 SIGNIFICANCE OF LISTENING

The ability to listen well is quite as important as the ability to speak well. In communication, however good a transmitter is, it becomes effective only in partnership with a good receiver. It is obvious that unless someone listens, any effort to communicate will be lost. After all, communication involves the negotiation of mutual meanings, which requires two parties.

Listening is a major ingredient of the communication process, and the lack